



RELOCATION GUIDE • NEW ZEALAND

Northland

Tē Tai Tokerau

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Northland.

Ethicare Resourcing

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Nau mai ki Tē Tai Tokerau

Welcome to Northland

Moving country is a bold thing to do, and it is rarely only about the job. This guide is here to make the practical parts easier: where people live, what the work is like, how you would get around, and what an ordinary week might actually feel like.

It is written by people who arrange these moves for a living, which means two things. We know the questions that arrive at two in the morning. And we would rather tell you the awkward parts now than have you find them in month three.

Nothing in here is a pitch. If Northland turns out to be the wrong answer for you, this guide should help you work that out just as quickly – and that is a good outcome, not a failed one.

Whatever you decide, you are welcome to ask us anything at all.

Sophie

FOUNDER, ETHICARE RESOURCING

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This is the short version. Every section here has a fuller chapter on our website, kept up to date — so if something looks time-sensitive, check there. We have left rents, salaries and other figures out on purpose: a number that was right when this was written would be quietly wrong by the time you read it, and a PDF cannot be corrected once it is sent. Those live on the site instead.

Welcome to Northland

Nau mai, haere mai ki Te Tai Tokerau. Northland is where New Zealand's story starts — the first meeting place of Māori and Europeans, the site of the Treaty, and the warmest, greenest, most coastline-heavy region in the country.

~200,000

People across the whole region — fewer than a single Auckland suburb cluster, spread over an area the size of a small country.

~55,000

In Whāngārei, the only city. Everything else is a town, a village or farmland.

2 HRS 15

Whāngārei to central Auckland on a good run. Close enough for a weekend, far enough to be a genuinely different life.

The winterless north

Northland is a long peninsula, three hundred kilometres from Auckland's northern edge to Cape Rēinga, with the Pacific on one side and the Tasman on the other. Nowhere in the region is more than about forty kilometres from the sea.

The climate is genuinely subtropical. Winters are mild enough that a frost is unusual near the coast, and the growing season runs most of the year. People call it the winterless north and it is not marketing — if you have moved from a cold country, or from a cold New Zealand house, the difference is the first thing you notice.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Northland specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally – visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools – lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Northland](#) for the full case including the reasons people leave, and [Where clinicians live](#) for the fourteen towns and suburbs compared.



02 THE CASE FOR NORTHLAND

Why Northland

Northland is the region clinicians either fall for completely or rule out in a week. It rewards a particular temperament, and the honest way to write this chapter is to describe both.

MONDAY TO FRIDAY

Ten to twenty minutes to work in Whāngārei, and parking is free and easy. If you're at a rural site, longer — but on empty roads.

AFTER WORK

Long light evenings most of the year. A swim, a walk up Mount Manaia, or the harbour at Town Basin. The water is warm enough to use from October to May.

SATURDAY

A beach on the east coast, the farmers' market, or the boat if you have one. Boat ownership is far more common here than anywhere else in New Zealand, and much cheaper than you'd expect.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. A nurse, physiotherapist or radiographer on a given step earns the same in Whāngārei as in Auckland. What changes is what the money buys and what the day feels like.

The offsets are real and worth naming: you will drive more and spend more on fuel, the retail and services market is thinner so some things cost more or take longer, and a specialist appointment for your own family may mean a trip to Auckland.

The six things people ask us

The opposite, usually. Northland is generalist practice — fewer subspecialists means you carry a broader scope and make more decisions yourself. Clinicians who want to deepen a narrow subspecialty should be in Auckland; clinicians who want to be a genuinely capable generalist often find this the best place in the country to do it. Chapter four covers what that means day to day.

Yes, and that is the honest answer. Whāngārei is a small city and the rest of the region is rural. Auckland is two and a quarter hours away, which is close enough for a weekend but not for a casual evening. If you need a dense city within reach, this will wear on you.

Who we'd steer to a main centre

Northland suits clinicians who want generalist breadth and a beach they don't share — the work is genuinely needed, which is its own kind of job satisfaction. The distances are real; the people who thrive treat the driving as part of the life, not a tax on it.



03

THE SHAPE OF IT

Northland at a glance

Northland is one long peninsula with two completely different coasts. Understanding that — and the single road that runs down the middle — tells you most of what you need about living here.

WHĀNGĀREI & THE HEADS

The region's only city, around 55,000, on a harbour with a rebuilt waterfront at Town Basin. The base hospital is here. Twenty minutes east, Whāngārei Heads and a string of beaches under Mount Manaia.

THE BAY OF ISLANDS

Kerikeri, Paihia, Russell and Waitangi, an hour north. Subtropical, historically the founding place of the nation, and the region's tourism heart. Kerikeri is the prosperous horticultural town; Paihia and Russell are on the water.

THE FAR NORTH

Kaitaia, Doubtless Bay, Ninety Mile Beach and Cape Rēinga. Remote, beautiful, and the most deprived part of the region. Rural health services matter enormously here.

The shape of the place

Three hundred kilometres from Auckland's northern boundary to Cape Rēinga, and rarely more than eighty wide. State Highway 1 runs the length of it, and almost everything hangs off that spine.

The east coast faces the Pacific: sheltered, island-scattered, warm and calm, with the Bay of Islands at its centre. This is the postcard Northland and where most of the population lives. The west coast faces the Tasman: wild, exposed, black-sand, with the Hokianga harbour and the great kauri forests behind it. Fewer people, harder beauty.

Subtropical, and what that actually means

Northland has the warmest, most humid climate in New Zealand. Two seasons dominate: a long warm summer and a mild wet winter. Spring and autumn are both pleasant and short.

Where New Zealand's story begins

This is not decoration — it shapes how healthcare is practised here. The Bay of Islands is where Māori and Europeans first sustained contact, where the first mission stations were established, and where Te Tiriti o Waitangi was signed in 1840.

Around a third of Northlanders identify as Māori, the highest of any region, and iwi and hapū are significant providers and partners in health services. You will encounter te ao Māori in clinical practice here more directly and more often than anywhere else in the country — karakia, whanaungatanga, working with whānau rather than individuals, and services delivered by Māori health providers.

Getting out

Whāngārei and Kerikeri both have small airports with connections to Auckland. Everything else goes by road: two and a quarter hours to central Auckland from Whāngārei, closer to four from Kaitaia. Auckland Airport, and therefore every international flight, is a further hour beyond the city.

Practically: a trip home to Europe or Africa is a long day before you even board. Plan for it, and budget for the Auckland leg.

Healthcare in Northland

Northland healthcare is generalist, geographically spread, and unusually close to the community it serves. For a clinician who wants breadth and autonomy, it is one of the most interesting places in the country to work. For one who wants a narrow subspecialty, it isn't.

WHĀNGĀREI HOSPITAL

The base hospital and the region's acute centre. Emergency department, inpatient medicine and surgery, maternity, ICU, and the hub for regional outpatient services.

RURAL HOSPITALS

Kaitaia in the Far North, Bay of Islands at Kawakawa, Dargaville on the Kauri Coast, and Rawene on the Hokianga. Genuine rural generalist practice, with retrieval and transfer as everyday considerations.

MĀORI HEALTH PROVIDERS

Iwi and hapū-led services deliver a significant share of primary and community care across the region, particularly in the Far North and Hokianga. Working alongside them is a normal part of practice here.

The shape of the service

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora runs public healthcare across the country. In Northland that means one base hospital in Whāngārei, a network of smaller rural hospitals and community services down the peninsula, and a strong presence of Māori health providers delivering care in partnership.

Whāngārei Hospital is the region's acute centre — emergency, medical and surgical inpatient services, maternity, intensive care, and the outpatient base for most specialties. Complex tertiary work is referred to Auckland, two and a quarter hours south.

What practising here is actually like

Four things come up repeatedly from clinicians we have placed in Northland. They are the same four things, read from two directions.

Pay comes from national collective agreements, so your salary here is the same as in Auckland. What changes is the work – broader scope, smaller teams, more autonomy, longer distances.

Everyday care, for you and your family

The national system – how public and private fit together, what ACC covers, what you pay – is set out in [Healthcare in New Zealand](#). What follows is Northland-specific.

Where clinicians live

Northland asks you a question the cities don't: how rural do you actually want to be? A Whāngārei suburb, a coastal village, a Bay of Islands town or the Far North are four genuinely different lives, and the drive between them is measured in hours.

ONE · CITY, COAST OR COUNTRY?

Whāngārei gives you the short commute, the hospital and the services. Whāngārei Heads and the east coast give you a beach at the end of the street and a twenty-five minute drive. Kerikeri and the Bay of Islands give you a prosperous small town an hour north. The Far North gives you space, deprivation and real remoteness. These are not variations on a theme.

TWO · DAMP OR DRY?

The Northland housing question. Older weatherboard houses near the coast can be persistently damp; newer builds and well-ventilated homes are fine. This matters more than insulation here — look for mould at window frames and in wardrobes, and ask what extraction the kitchen and bathroom have.

THREE · HOW FAR WILL YOU REALLY DRIVE?

Everyone overestimates this. An hour each way to Kerikeri sounds romantic in February and wears thin by July, especially on a winding road in the rain. If you're rostered on call, be conservative.

Pick your site, then read down

Places reorder by commute to whichever site you select. Rents are indicative weekly figures for a three-bedroom house as at July 2026 — treat them as a shape, not a quote.

Commutes are typical door-to-door driving times. Northland has no real peak outside Whāngārei, but roads wind and summer holiday traffic adds significantly. Rents move; check current listings before budgeting.

Cost of living

Clinical pay is national, so your salary in Whāngārei is the same as in Auckland. That gap is the financial case — tempered by fuel, distance and a thinner market.

FUEL, AND LOTS OF IT

The biggest difference from a city budget. Long distances, winding roads and often two cars. Households here routinely spend two or three times what a central-city equivalent would.

DEHUMIDIFYING, NOT HEATING

Winter power bills are lower than the South Island's because it rarely gets cold. But a dehumidifier running through a damp winter is a real line item, and worth it.

THE AUCKLAND TRIP

Budget for several a year — specialist appointments, the airport, a proper shop, a concert. Fuel, sometimes a night's accommodation, and a whole day.

Why there are no prices on this page

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Northland against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The gap, and what eats into it

New Zealand's public health pay comes from national collective agreements, so the figure on your contract does not change with the region. Northland housing costs a fraction of Auckland's, and less than Wellington's or Christchurch's. On paper the saving is the largest of any destination in this guide.

Three things eat into it, and they are worth naming honestly. You will drive far more, and fuel in rural Northland is generally dearer than in the cities. The retail market is smaller, so some goods cost more or arrive slower, and a serious shopping trip may mean Auckland. And if your family needs specialist care that isn't available locally, that is a day and a tank of petrol.

Everyday prices

Indicative New Zealand dollars as at July 2026. Prices move; treat these as a shape.

Two household budgets

Indicative New Zealand dollars per month as at July 2026, for a household living moderately. Your own numbers will differ — treat this as a shape to sanity-check against, not a quote.

The two budgets below, at true relative scale. Northland's cheap housing is real — and it is not what decides a family's month.

The Northland-specific costs

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.



07 ROADS AND DISTANCE

Getting around

Northland has one road spine, no trains, and long distances between everything. A reliable car is not a lifestyle preference here — it is a condition of living in the region.

**WINDING, NARROW,
UNDULATING**

Most of the region's roads. Overtaking opportunities are limited and passing lanes are the exception. Allow more time than the map suggests and don't plan tight connections.

**UNSEALED ROADS ARE
NORMAL**

Many beaches, rural addresses and forest tracks are reached on gravel. It is not four-wheel-drive territory, but a low-slung car will suffer and you will wash it constantly.

RAIN AND SLIPS

Northland gets heavy subtropical rain, and slips close roads. In a big weather event a route can be shut for days, with a long detour. Rural staff plan around this.

State Highway 1, and everything hanging off it

SH1 runs the length of the peninsula from Auckland to Cape Rēinga. Almost every journey you make will use part of it. The section from Auckland to Whāngārei has been progressively improved and is the fastest stretch; north of Whāngārei it becomes a two-lane rural highway, and stays that way.

The thing that surprises people: Northland roads wind. A distance that looks like forty minutes on a map is frequently an hour, because the road follows hills and harbour edges rather than cutting through them. Locals quote everything in driving time, and within a month you will too.

Driving here

New Zealand drives on the left, and most overseas licences are valid for twelve months before conversion — the process is national and set out in [Driving & licences](#). What is specific to Northland is the conditions.

Buses, flights and the water

Whāngārei has a small local bus network covering the main suburban routes; useful if you live on one, not a substitute for a car. Intercity coaches run the SH1 corridor to Auckland and up to the Bay of Islands.

Whāngārei and Kerikeri both have small airports with regular short flights to Auckland. For a day of meetings in the city, or connecting to an international departure, flying can be worth the fare over four and a half hours of round-trip driving.



08

DAILY LIFE

Food, shopping & the everyday

Northland's food is better than its size suggests and worse than a city's, and both halves matter. The produce is exceptional; the choice on a wet Tuesday night is not.

TOWN BASIN, WHĀNGĀREI

The rebuilt marina precinct and the best of the city's eating — restaurants and cafés along the water, the Hundertwasser Art Centre, and a Saturday growers' market nearby.

KERIKERI

Punches well above its weight. A genuine food town — orchards and growers on the doorstep, good restaurants, a strong Sunday market, and several established wineries within a short drive.

PAIHIA & RUSSELL

Waterfront dining aimed partly at visitors, and good for it in summer. Russell in particular has a couple of long-standing places worth the ferry.



An ordinary evening out in Whāngārei. The choice is smaller than a city's, and the tables still fill.

The weekly shop

Groceries in New Zealand are expensive by international standards, and rural Northland is no cheaper. Knowing the chains helps.

Bring reusable bags. Single-use plastic bags are banned nationwide.

The honest limitations

This is where a small region shows. Restaurant choice outside Whāngārei and Kerikeri is limited, and many places close early or don't open Mondays and Tuesdays. Cuisines that a city takes for granted — good Vietnamese, Ethiopian, Korean — are thin on the ground or absent.

Specialty grocery is the bigger gap. Northland does not have the concentrated South Asian, East Asian or African grocers that Auckland does. Most people manage with a combination of the supermarket's international aisle, online ordering from Auckland suppliers, and a stock-up whenever they're in the city.

Furnishing an empty house

Whāngārei has the big-box retailers for whiteware and flat-pack. Beyond that, Trade Me and Facebook Marketplace are how Northland actually buys furniture, and the market is good because people move in and out of the region constantly. Check the delivery position before you order anything large to a rural address — surcharges are common and some retailers won't come north of the city.



09

WEEKENDS

Two coasts & the water

This is what Northland is for. Two coasts, two hundred beaches, the oldest forest in the country, and the founding place of the nation — all within an easy drive of wherever you live.

**15 MIN · WHĀNGĀREI FALLS
& THE KAURI PARKS**

A twenty-six metre waterfall on the edge of the city, and the A.H. Reed park with a canopy walkway through mature kauri. Both are ordinary after-work destinations, not expeditions.

25 MIN · WHĀNGĀREI HEADS

The harbour road out to Parua Bay, Ocean Beach and Mount Manaia — a steep, short climb with one of the best views in the north. Surf, sheltered swimming and boat ramps all along the way.

**40 MIN · THE SOUTHERN
BEACHES**

Ruakaka and Waipu Cove — long, safe, patrolled surf beaches. Waipu Caves nearby have glow-worms and cost nothing to visit.

No city glow to speak of — the night sky is one of the things people who move here mention first. Photograph by Emad Kabiri, anaesthetic technician

On the water

This is the thing that most distinguishes Northland from anywhere else in this guide. Boat ownership here is ordinary rather than aspirational — a modest trailer boat is within reach on a clinical salary, ramps are everywhere, and the sheltered east coast is forgiving water.

Fishing is good and genuinely accessible; snapper off the Heads is a normal Saturday. Diving at the Poor Knights is what people travel for. Kayaking the mangrove estuaries, sailing in the Bay of Islands, and swimming from October through to May in water that stays warm long after the rest of the country has given up.

History you can stand in

Waitangi is forty minutes from Kerikeri, and the Treaty Grounds are the most significant historical site in the country – the meeting house, the waka, and the ground where Te Tiriti was signed in 1840. Kerikeri has the oldest surviving buildings in New Zealand, the Stone Store and Kemp House, on a river basin that has barely changed.

Russell, across the water from Paihia, was the country's first European settlement and briefly its capital. Ruapekapeka pā south of Kawakawa is one of the best-preserved battle sites of the New Zealand Wars.

What you give up

An honest close. Northland has almost no live music, theatre or nightlife by city standards, and what exists is concentrated in Whāngārei. Big concerts, exhibitions and international sport mean Auckland. Sunday in a small town is very quiet.

And the region genuinely empties and fills with the seasons. January is crowded, roads are busy and everything is booked; June is beautiful, empty and a little melancholy. Some people love that rhythm and some find the winters long.

Where to go next

You do not need a moving date, a decision or a CV to talk to us. If Northland is on your list, tell us what you do and what you are weighing up, and we will be straight with you about whether we can help.

Everything on our website is free to read whether or not you ever work with us.

The full Northland guide – ethicareresourcing.com/destinations/northland-new-zealand

Registration pathway checker – ethicareresourcing.com/pathway-checker

What reaches your bank account – ethicareresourcing.com/take-home-pay

What the move itself costs – ethicareresourcing.com/cost-calculator

Talk to us – hello@ethicareresourcing.com
